

Making sense of the world

THE WEEK

Junior

Mikaela Shiffrin
USA

Max Langenhan
Germany

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USA

Miho Takagi
Japan

Ilia Malinin
USA

WINTER GAMES

Get set for a celebration of snow, skill, and speed at the Milan Cortina Olympics **p12**

THE BEST MAGAZINE FOR CURIOUS KIDS



This week's big news



A memorial for Alex Pretti

DID YOU KNOW?

Minneapolis, Minnesota, runs along the Mississippi River and has a population of nearly 429,000 people.

If you feel worried



It's understandable that you might feel upset about what's happening in Minneapolis. If you do, talk with a trusted adult, share your feelings, and ask questions about things you're concerned about. Limit your exposure to news meant for adults, and do things you enjoy. Talk to your family about ways to help others.

Clashes escalate in Minneapolis

Anger and unrest are growing across the US after two fatal shootings by federal agents in Minneapolis, Minnesota, less than three weeks apart. The agents are employed by the US Department of Homeland Security (DHS), which oversees the Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency (ICE).

Why is ICE in Minneapolis?

DHS and ICE implement the US government's efforts to deport (remove from the country) people from other countries who are in the US without legal permission. Since President Donald Trump took office in January 2025, DHS and ICE have detained thousands of people they said were undocumented immigrants. They have also faced criticism for their aggressive tactics and wrongful detentions. Thousands of people who are opposed to these actions have tried to disrupt them through protests. Some protesters have been arrested on charges such as interfering with DHS operations.



Jacob Frey

What did federal agents do?

On January 24, people were protesting as DHS agents detained someone in Minneapolis. The protesters included Alex Pretti, age 37, a nurse at a veterans hospital in the city. Agents shoved and pepper-sprayed him and others, then pinned Pretti

to the ground, removed a gun they found in his waistband, and shot him with their own weapons. Tensions were already high in the city after an ICE agent killed a woman named Renee Good on January 7. After her death, people in Minneapolis and across the country took to the streets calling for ICE and DHS to leave the city. In response, Trump sent 2,000 more agents to Minneapolis. US officials initially barred local law enforcement from participating in investigations into either incident, leading to claims of bias.

What have government leaders said?

Within hours of the shooting, US government officials said Pretti was a "would-be assassin" who attacked agents. Local authorities disputed this, saying Pretti wasn't threatening agents and was exercising his legal right to protest and carry a gun. It is legal to carry a registered firearm in Minnesota, and Pretti's gun was licensed. On January 25, Minnesota Governor Tim Walz, a Democrat, said DHS agents "are sowing chaos and violence" and using deadly force. He asked Trump, a Republican, to remove them from the state. "President Trump, you can end this today," Walz said. "Please show some decency." After Good's death, Democratic elected officials criticized the actions of the DHS. Since Pretti's killing, several Republican lawmakers joined them

in calling for the DHS to back down and for a full investigation into Pretti's death. In a rare move, three former Presidents—Democrats Bill Clinton, Barack Obama, and Joe Biden—spoke out. Obama said the DHS was using "tactics that seem designed to intimidate, harass, provoke, and endanger the residents of a major American city."

How have people in the city reacted?

Several hundred people have gathered in frigid conditions at a memorial for Pretti at the site of the shooting. A church one block away opened its doors so people could get warm, and volunteers handed out hot drinks and food. Large groups have gathered outside City Hall, and more than 1,000 people joined a group called "Singing Resistance" to sing protest songs together as they peacefully marched in Minneapolis. Protests and vigils have also taken place in cities and towns across the US.

What will happen next?

On January 26, Walz and Minneapolis Mayor Jacob Frey said they had spoken with Trump and he had agreed to reduce the number of agents in the city and let the state investigate the shooting. Trump sent Tom Homan, head of the DHS, to Minneapolis to take over operations there. The agents involved in Pretti's death were also placed on leave. Democrats in Congress said they would block a major funding bill unless ICE is reformed. If the bill is blocked, the government could shut down on January 31.



Oldest rock art found in cave

Scientists said a drawing on the wall of a cave on Sulawesi island, in Indonesia, was 67,800 years old, making it the world's oldest known rock art. The stenciled hand is more than 15,000 years older than similar art nearby and 1,100 years older than the previously known oldest drawing, made by a Neanderthal (human ancestor) in Spain. The scientists analyzed mineral deposits on top of and underneath the art to determine its age.

The hand stencil is faded but faintly visible between two more recent drawings. Researchers said the fingers were purposely altered to look narrower, an artistic technique found in other drawings in the area. This may have been to make the hand look more like a claw, possibly to signify a connection between humans and animals.

Based on the complexity of the work, scientists think it was likely made by early Homo sapiens (modern humans). This would make it the oldest evidence of the presence of modern humans in the region. They may have been part of a larger group that eventually spread to what is now Australia.



The hand stencil (in circle)



A wolverine

WEIGHTY WEASELS

Adult wolverines are between 2 and 3.5 feet long and can weigh up to 40 pounds.

Colorado to reintroduce wolverines

The Colorado Parks and Wildlife (CPW) agency announced a plan to reintroduce wolverines in the state, where they have not lived permanently since the early 1900s. Colorado will become the first state in the US to try to reintroduce the animals into the wild.

Wolverines are members of the weasel family that typically live in high-elevation areas. They are native to Colorado but went extinct there by 1919, in large part because of human activity like hunting. Now the animals are threatened with extinction across the country. Conservation experts estimate that there are about 300 wolverines left in California, Montana, and other states.

Wildlife officials said Colorado provides an ideal habitat for the animals. They estimate that the state could eventually hold between

100 and 180 individuals, which is about how many lived there before they went extinct.

CPW's plan calls for safely capturing wolverines from parts of the US and Canada where their populations are at steady levels and transporting them to Colorado. The wolverines released into the wild there will have tracking collars, and wildlife officials will carefully monitor their health.

According to the plan, 45 wolverines will be released into the wild over a period of three years, enough time to establish a healthy breeding population. The wolverines will be released into three mountainous areas in Colorado, including parts of Rocky Mountain National Park.

CPW officials said the plan is an important step toward saving the wolverine. They did not give a date when the initiative would begin.



IT'S AN AMAZING WEEK FOR...

A STAR SNOWPLOW

Country music icon and Tennessee native Dolly Parton has a new namesake in the city of Nashville: a snowplow named Dolly Plowton. The truck, which was named by local students, hit the road during last week's big snowstorm.



The new plow



The dinosaur dig

A DINO-MITE DISCOVERY

For the first time in more than 100 years, dinosaur fossils were uncovered at Dinosaur National Monument, which straddles Colorado and Utah. Workers first spotted the bones of a long-necked creature—likely a Diplodocus—while a parking lot was being constructed.

CHANGING LIVES

Top-ranked tennis player Coco Gauff donated \$150,000 to UNCF, a nonprofit that supports HBCUs (Historically Black Colleges and Universities). Her donation will fund scholarships for student athletes who play competitive tennis. "I hope this gift will help students achieve their dreams," Gauff said.



Coco Gauff



National news

SNOW DAY

The city of Silver Lake, Colorado, holds the record for the most snowfall in 24 hours with 75 inches, set in 1921.



A street in Albany, New York, on January 26

A snowboarder's surprise



Shaun White, age 39, an Olympic gold medalist who retired from snowboarding in 2022, put on a surprise show in New York City's Central Park during the storm. On January 25, he performed snowboarding tricks (shown above) in front of onlookers. White will work as an NBC analyst for this year's Winter Games.

Major snowstorm sweeps across US

Winter Storm Fern dumped heavy snow across the US, from New Mexico to Maine, bringing treacherous ice and frigid temperatures that have affected more than 200 million people.

What happened?

On January 23, Fern began dropping snow in the West, then traveled to Texas and across the South before making its way to the East and North. The city of Bonito Lake, New Mexico, received 31 inches, the most in the country, followed by 30 inches in Napanoch, New York, and 24.7 inches in Jennerstown, Pennsylvania. Major cities such as Boston, Massachusetts (16.7 inches), and New York City (11.4 inches) received more snow than they had in a decade or more. The National Weather Service also

received more than 700 reports of freezing rain or ice storm damage, including in North Carolina, South Carolina, and Texas.

What was the impact?

At least 30 people died during the storm. More than 1 million customers lost power, and about 380,000 were still without electricity when *The Week Junior* went to press. In Alabama, more than an inch of ice caused at least 100 trees to fall across roadways, creating unsafe driving conditions. About 11,000 flights were canceled as airports struggled to clear runways. On January 26, as communities began recovering from the storm, most schools across the US were closed, including in major cities like Atlanta, Georgia, and Cincinnati, Ohio.

How are people being helped?

Many governors called in National Guard troops to offer help, and at least 20 states declared a state of emergency to protect people and activate assistance. Warming centers were set up for people who had lost power or heat. Kentucky opened 113 warming facilities across the state, for example. The city of Springfield, Missouri, created additional cold weather shelters where people could stay overnight.

What will happen next?

Frigid temperatures were predicted to continue through the week. Utility crews were working to restore power, with officials in some cities, including Nashville, Tennessee, warning that the process could take several days.



WORD OF THE WEEK

RECIPE

In the late Middle Ages, "recipe" referred to a prescription for medicine. The word is derived from a Latin command meaning "take" and refers to a doctor's instruction to take a remedy for an illness. Later, it came to be used for following other instructions, especially those involving food preparation.



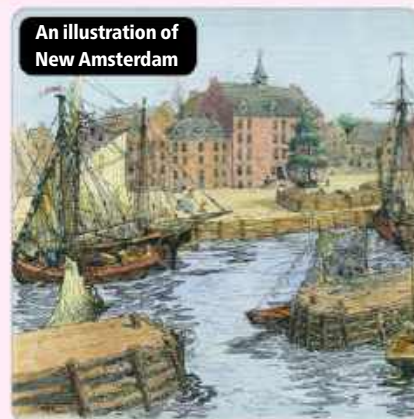
THE WEEK IN HISTORY

February 2, 1653

New Amsterdam becomes a city

On February 2, 1653, New Amsterdam became a city when Dutch officials put its charter into effect. Previously, it had been a settlement representing the Netherlands after the Dutch West India Company purchased the land from the local Lenape Native Americans in 1626. In 1664, control of the city was transferred to the English and it was renamed New York City.

An illustration of New Amsterdam



National news



Suni Williams

Astronaut retires from NASA

After 27 years of service, Suni Williams, age 60, retired from NASA, the US space agency. She set a record for the most spacewalking time by a woman: 62 hours during nine excursions to the ISS, a laboratory orbiting 254 miles from Earth. In June 2024, Williams and astronaut Butch Wilmore arrived at the ISS for a mission that was meant to last for eight days. Due to a technical problem, they stayed for nine months and arrived home in March 2025.



Carlos Beltrán

Andruw Jones

Baseball players to be honored

Former Major League Baseball players Carlos Beltrán and Andruw Jones will be the 2026 inductees into the National Baseball Hall of Fame, an honor determined by the Baseball Writers' Association of America. Beltrán, who was in his fourth year of eligibility, was elected with 84.2% of the vote, while Jones, in his ninth year, received 78.4%. They will be inducted in July in Cooperstown, New York.



A view of the nest

Famous eagles lay first egg

Bald eagle mates Jackie and Shadow, whose nest in Big Bear, California, can be viewed on a live cam at friendsofbigbearvalley.org, welcomed their first egg of 2026. On January 23, experts noticed Jackie shifting her weight and lifting her feathers before laying the egg. Last year, the pair successfully raised two eaglets, Sunny and Gizmo. Incubation for an egg typically lasts about 35 days.



Some of the year's winning books

WOW!
A total of seven authors have received the Newbery Medal more than once.

Children's book prizes announced

The 2026 awards for best books and digital media for children and young adults were announced on January 26. The American Library Association (ALA), the world's largest and oldest library association, named the winners, which were chosen by librarians.

The Newbery Medal, established in 1922, is given to the best children's book of the year. It is named after John Newbery, one of the first people to publish books for children. This year, the medal went to *All the Blues in the Sky* by Renée Watson. Told through poetry and prose, the novel focuses on 13-year-old Sage, who is grieving the sudden death of her best friend. Watson is best known for her novel *Piecing Me Together*, which won both a Newbery Honor and a Coretta Scott King Author Award in 2018.

The Coretta Scott King Award was created in 1969 to honor civil rights legend Martin Luther King Jr. and his wife, Coretta Scott King. The 2026 winner was the historical fiction novel *Will's Race for Home* by Jewell Parker Rhodes. Set in 1889, the book is about a Black

father and son who go on a dangerous journey from Texas to Oklahoma to claim land of their own.

Honor books, which are runners-up, were also announced. Four titles were named Newbery honor books: *The Nine Moons of Han Yu and Luli* by Karina Yan Glaser, *A Sea of Lemon Trees: The Corrido of Roberto Alvarez* by María Dolores Águila, *The Teacher of Nomad Land: A World War II Story* by Daniel Nayeri, and *The*

Undead Fox of Deadwood Forest by Aubrey Hartman. Three books received Coretta Scott King honors: *The Incredibly Human Henson Blayze* by Derrick Barnes, *The Library in the Woods* by Calvin Alexander Ramsey, and *Split the Sky* by Marie Arnold.

The ALA also announced the winner of the Caldecott Medal, an award created in 1937 that recognizes the year's best picture



The Caldecott Medal winner

book for children. The 2026 prize went to *Fireworks*, written by Matthew Burgess and illustrated by Cátia Chien. The story captures the rhythm of a steamy day as two siblings wait for a Fourth of July celebration to begin.

THE WEEK'S SILLIEST HEADLINE

"Escaped parakeet flies into kindergarten classroom, lands on girl" UPI





Around the world



A European bison

El Recuenco, Spain **Bison introduced to wild lands**

Experts released nine European bison into the wild in the Iberian Highlands region. Europe's largest land mammals have made a comeback after nearly going extinct in the 1920s. This reintroduction is part of an international research project to see how the creatures can help restore ecosystems. By grazing on plants in a local woodland, the bison could also help reduce the risk of wildfires.



Presenting the record

Mexico City, Mexico **Embroidered tapestry sets record**

An exhibition in Mexico's capital has broken the record for the world's largest display of embroidery, a type of sewing art. Local artists stitched 3,106 square pieces, and Mexico's Ministry of Tourism assembled their work into a tapestry with 32 panels to represent all 31 Mexican states and the capital city. Organizers said they wanted to showcase the country's cultural history and "shout to the whole world that Mexico is amazing."



A rally for release

Venezuela **Political prisoners released**

The human rights group Foro Penal announced that at least 266 political prisoners have been released from prison in Venezuela. A political prisoner is a person who is jailed because of their political beliefs or for standing up to their government. The releases followed the US arrest of former Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro on January 3.

France **Child-free train travel**

France's high-speed rail service has launched a new train section where children aren't allowed. The Optimum Plus car is designed to be a quiet and comfortable space for business travelers. It is similar to first class, but passengers must be over the age of 12. This rule has led some people to criticize the company for excluding children.



A train



Arar, Saudi Arabia **Mummies found**

Scientists have discovered seven mummified cheetahs in caves near the city of Arar. Mummification is a process that preserves a dead body. Ancient Egyptians used a special mummification technique, but it can also occur naturally in ice, bogs, or sand. Researchers aren't sure how the cheetahs were mummified. Bones from 54 cheetahs were also found in the caves. The remains range from 130 to more than 1,800 years old.



One of the cheetahs

GUINNESS WORLD RECORDS: GETTY IMAGES (2); AHMED BOUG ET AL.; COMMUNICATIONS EARTH & ENVIRONMENT; DANIEL MIRIEUX; ALAMY (5)

Around the world



A Tapanuli orangutan

North Sumatra, Indonesia **Protecting rare orangutans**

Authorities are taking action to protect the world's rarest ape. In 2025, floods and landslides in the Batang Toru forest area led to the deaths of at least 50 of Earth's last 800 Tapanuli orangutans. An investigation found that mining companies may have damaged the habitat. Officials are now banning 28 companies from operating in the area.



Xiao Xiao and Lei Lei

Tokyo, Japan **Japan returns pandas to China**

Thousands of visitors gathered at Ueno Zoo on January 25 to see twin panda cubs Xiao Xiao and Lei Lei before the animals went back to China. The Chinese government often loans pandas to other countries as a gesture of goodwill, but its relationship with Japan has recently worsened. The loan of Xiao Xiao and Lei Lei was set to end in February, but they were returned early. Japan currently has no pandas for the first time since 1972.



Alex Honnold

Taipei, Taiwan **Climber reaches top of skyscraper**

On the morning of January 25, daredevil climber Alex Honnold climbed to the top of one of the world's tallest buildings without any ropes or safety nets to protect him. The Taipei 101 skyscraper is 1,667 feet tall and has 101 floors. Pausing for short rests on balconies along the way, Honnold reached the top of the building in just over 90 minutes. His climb was broadcast live on Netflix.



The hospital

Khartoum, Sudan **Hospital reopens**

Three years after it was forced to close, Bahri Teaching Hospital has reopened. The hospital was severely damaged in 2023 when a civil war (conflict between groups within a country) broke out. Before the hospital shut down, its emergency department treated about 800 patients a day. It is one of about 40 hospitals that have resumed operating in Khartoum.

Rwanda **AI in health clinics**

Technology powered by artificial intelligence (AI) will be tested in 50 health clinics across Rwanda. AI is a computer system that can learn and adapt like humans do. Led by the nonprofit Gates Foundation and a company called OpenAI, the new initiative aims to improve health care throughout Africa. Organizers of the project hope the technology will help medical workers treat people more quickly and effectively.



A medical researcher



The big debate

Should law enforcement use robot dogs?

Police have started using robot dogs, but not everyone thinks that's a good idea.

What you need to know

- US law enforcement agencies have used robots for decades, although robot dogs are a newer technology.
- The robot dog used by most police departments is called Spot, made by a company called Boston Dynamics.
- More than 60 police departments in Massachusetts, Texas, New York, Hawaii, and other US states have used or tested robot dogs.
- Countries including China, Indonesia, United Arab Emirates, and Canada have reportedly used them too.



Law enforcement agencies in the US have been using robots since the 1980s. They have included units on wheels that defuse explosive devices and drones that fly over natural disasters. Then, when Boston Dynamics unleashed Spot in 2019, police, sheriff, bomb squad, and other departments began using the animal-like machines. With four legs, a strong arm, and a sturdy frame, the 75-pound robot is about the size of a German Shepherd and much more agile than robots that roll around. Some people say, though, that units like Spot don't belong in policing. What do you think? Should law enforcement use robot dogs?

Yes—they help keep people safe

Robot dogs like Spot can do things that human officers and K-9 police dogs can't. They have 360° cameras and heat sensing technology, which help find people who are trapped or hidden, and they never get tired or need a break. The units are built to be sturdy and can walk over uneven surfaces, climb stairs, open doors, and carry heavy loads. They're well suited to situations that are too dangerous for people or K-9s, like chemical spills and earthquakes. Robot dogs can also patrol public areas when human officers are unavailable. This is especially helpful for agencies in major cities that have a lot of people and places to protect.

No—machines aren't the way to go

Each robot dog can cost about \$100,000 or more, which is money that would be put to better use hiring more officers or funding other services. And for that price, they can still break down, fall over, or bump into things. The machines also take away the important human connection in law enforcement. Officers should interact with members of the communities they protect so they get to know them and understand their concerns. A robot just doesn't care about people in the same way. And robot dogs can record audio, video, and pictures of people who may not realize that the quirky little machine is "watching" them. That's not right.

YES Three reasons law enforcement should use robot dogs

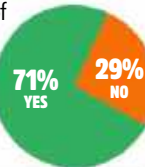
- 1 With their advanced technology, they can do things that human officers and police dogs can't do.
- 2 Sending machines into very dangerous situations, like disaster zones, helps keep humans and K-9s safe.
- 3 When there aren't enough officers, robot dogs can help protect big cities.

NO Three reasons law enforcement should not use robot dogs

- 1 The money spent on the machines could be put to much better use.
- 2 Robots can't replace police officers who interact with and get to know the people in their communities.
- 3 The high-tech dogs can record data about people without their knowledge, which is an invasion of privacy.

LAST WEEK'S POLL

Last week, we asked if chewy cookies are better than crispy ones. When it comes to your cookies, most of you prefer soft ones: 71% said yes, and 29% said no.



What do you think?

Now that you've read a bit more about this issue, visit kids.theweekjunior.com/polls so you can vote in our debate. Vote **YES** if you think law enforcement should use robot dogs or **NO** if you don't. We'll publish the results next week.

The goal of the big debate is to present two sides of an issue fairly in order to stimulate discussion and allow our readers to make up their minds. The views on this page do not reflect those of *The Week Junior*, and the page is not funded by third parties.



Writing with heart

Chanel Miller is a best-selling author and illustrator whose 2025 debut middle-grade novel, *Magnolia Wu Unfolds It All*, earned a Newbery Honor. In January, she released a second book, *The Moon Without Stars*. *The Week Junior* spoke to her about her experience as a writer.

Did you enjoy reading as a child?

Yes! I remember my grandma taking me to a book signing for Felicia Bond, the illustrator of *If You Give a Mouse a Cookie*. It blew my mind to realize that authors and illustrators were real people. I wanted to be one of them.

When did you first write your own stories?

My second-grade teacher had us write stories, and she would laminate the covers and bind the books. I “published” eight books. We even read them aloud to parents in the auditorium. Having your work taken seriously at that age was powerful.

What is the best part of the process?

Writing is meticulous—every word has to be just right. With illustrating, I use a

different part of my brain. I can be more playful and less worried about perfection.

What inspired your new book?

The main character, Luna, is a book doctor. People come to her with their issues, and she prescribes books that might help. I do that in my own life. Books don’t fix everything, but they can keep you company through hard moments.

What would you say to kids who are going through middle school right now?

Change is inevitable. Try thinking of your life as chapters—this isn’t the whole book.

Any advice for aspiring writers?

Squash your self-doubt and follow your biggest ideas. See where they go.

MANY TALENTS

In 2020, Chanel Miller created a large-scale mural for the Asian Art Museum in San Francisco, California.



Chanel Miller

Chess star wins big

Norwegian chess player Magnus Carlsen recently won his ninth World Blitz Chess Championship, setting a new record for the most blitz titles. In blitz chess, players get a few minutes, compared to classical games, which can last hours. Carlsen—one of the game’s greatest players with the highest rating in history—is known for his calm, calculated plays and dramatic comebacks. His win also gave him his 20th world championship in chess. He said the blitz title is important to him: “It’s very challenging—and very satisfying to win.”



Magnus Carlsen



June Squibb

A theatrical return

More than 60 years after making her Broadway debut in a small role in the musical *Gypsy*, 96-year-old June Squibb is starring in her first lead role on Broadway in the play *Marjorie Prime*. She plays an elderly woman whose memories are fading in a futuristic world of artificial intelligence. Squibb has been acting since the 1950s, but most of her prominent roles have come in the past 15 years, including an Oscar-nominated supporting role in *Nebraska* (2013). In 2025, she starred in the film *Eleanor the Great*. About making her Broadway return, Squibb said, “It’s like going back home.”

OVERHEARD



“It definitely made me want to be competitive. I wanted to be great at something.”

Michael B. Jordan on sharing a name with basketball legend Michael Jordan. He has starred in the films *Creed* and *Black Panther* and received his first Oscar nomination this year for Best Actor in *Sinners*.



POLAR PLUNGE

Polar bears can dive 15 feet underwater and can swim more than 60 miles without stopping.



A polar bear on rocky terrain

Polar bears adapt to change

Climate change is a huge threat to polar bears, but scientists now believe that some of the animals are evolving to survive in a world with higher temperatures and less sea ice. Adapting to these conditions is altering the bears' DNA (complex chemical that carries instructions for how a living thing should grow and develop).

Most polar bears live on sea ice in the Arctic region, including parts of Greenland. They rely on the ice as a base to hunt animals like seals, which make up most of their high-fat diet. But as global temperatures rise, sea ice is melting. If this continues, experts predict that more than 60% of the polar bear population could vanish by 2050.

Scientists compared polar bears in northern Greenland to an isolated group living in southern Greenland, where temperatures are warmer and there is less sea ice. Both groups of bears were once part of the same population, but some moved south about 200 years ago. To understand how the southern population is surviving, a team of researchers analyzed DNA samples from 17 bears.



Southern Greenland is outside the Arctic Circle.

All animals have pieces of DNA called "jumping genes" that can move from one location to another. When they move, they can change how other genes (sections of DNA) behave. The study found that jumping genes were more active in the southern bears compared to their northern counterparts. This increased activity seemed to be linked to higher temperatures.

The genes caused changes in how the bears' bodies cope with heat and how they age.

They also affected how the body processes fat, which becomes important when food is scarce. According to the study, the southern bears have been eating more plants instead of fatty seals.

Lead researcher Alice Godden called the study's results "hopeful" because they show that polar bears are rewriting their DNA to adapt to climate change.

However, she said, this is a "desperate survival mechanism against melting sea ice" and Godden pointed out that there are limits to how much the animals can adapt. "We still need to be doing everything we can to slow temperature increases," she told *The Guardian*.

The incredible body of a bear



Polar bears might look white, but they actually have black skin and blue or black tongues. Their fur is transparent (see-through) and colorless and only looks white because it reflects the light. To stay warm, they have two layers of fur and a layer of fat, which can be more than 4 inches thick. Their paws are covered in soft bumps to help them grip the ice — sort of like slipper socks. Because they are at the top of the Arctic food chain, polar bears' survival relies on the health of many other species living in the region. The big bears can travel thousands of miles in a year, burning off all the food they eat by being on the move.



A MATTER OF PRIDE

Lions are the only cat species known to roar together as a group.



A lion

The secret sounds of lions' roars

Lions are famous for their dramatic roars, which they use to mark their territory and communicate with other lions. In a recent study, scientists gathered recordings of 3,149 African lion sounds from Tanzania and Zimbabwe and had artificial intelligence (AI, when a computer imitates human learning) analyze them.

The team's analysis found that lions are actually making two different sounds when they roar. The first is the well-known, full-throated roar, which is loud and varies in pitch. This is followed by a

shorter "intermediate roar" with less variation and a lower pitch. Scientists say it is not clear what this intermediate roar is meant to communicate.

Individual lions have their own unique roars. In this study, AI could identify individual lions based on their roars with an accuracy rate of nearly 95%, which was a better rate than humans could achieve. This suggests that AI could be helpful for estimating how many lions are in an area or keeping track of individual animals, which could improve conservation efforts.

Animal of the week

Big Cypress fox squirrel



After two months in an animal hospital recovering from injuries, two Big Cypress fox squirrels have returned to the wild. The rare pair bonded during their stay and were cleared for release once they could climb, jump, and crack nuts on their own.

- **LIFESPAN:** 8 to 18 years
- **HABITAT:** Forests and swamps in South Florida
- **SIZE:** 17 to 27 inches long
- **DIET:** Nuts, seeds, fruits, and some insects
- **FUN FACT:** These squirrels can jump more than 6 feet and twist their ankles 180 degrees backward.



Good week / Bad week



Octopuses

Record sightings in British waters last year led experts in the UK to call 2025 the "year of the octopus." Scientists think warmer winters resulted in a big "bloom" of octopus births. They are waiting to see if the trend will continue.



Whales in New York

Cleaner water and abundant prey have attracted more whales to New York Harbor, but the busy waterway is becoming dangerous for the animals. Collisions with boats and fishing gear have led to a rise in whale injuries and deaths.



"What is the fastest living animal known?"

Rithik, 9, Texas

Ron Magill
Wildlife expert,
Zoo Miami

Many people think it's the cheetah, which can attain speeds of about 70 miles per hour, but the fastest living animal is a bird! The peregrine falcon can reach speeds that exceed 200 miles per hour in what is called a "stoop." The falcon tucks in its wings and dives from above to attack prey.



A peregrine falcon

Do you have a question for an animal expert? Send it to hello@theweekjunior.com. Find out more about Zoo Miami at zoomiami.org.



Let the Winter Games

Find out everything you need to know about the 2026 Olympics.

The Winter Olympics officially begin in Italy, in the city of Milan and the town of Cortina d'Ampezzo, on February 6, in a celebration of snow, skill, and speed. About 2,900 athletes representing 93 countries will compete in 16 sports. Check out this four-page preview for details about the star athletes, medals, mascots, and more!

This year's Olympics

Milan Cortina 2026 will make Olympic history, with women making up 47% of the athletes—the most ever at a Winter Games. There are also a record 50 women's events. For the first time at the Games, men and women will race the same distances in cross-country skiing. There will also be new events in existing sports, like team combined in alpine skiing, and women's doubles in luge. And a new sport, ski mountaineering, is making its Olympic debut.



US alpine skier
Mikaela Shiffrin

History of the Games



The Olympic Winter Games began in 1924 in the French Alps in Chamonix, France. More than 250 athletes from 16 countries competed over 10 days. There were 16 events spanning nine disciplines: bobsled, cross-country skiing, curling, figure skating, ice hockey, military patrol (similar to biathlon), Nordic combined, ski jumping, and speed skating. Norwegian figure skater Sonja Henie made her Olympic debut at age 11 (above) and went on to win three Olympic gold medals in women's singles in 1928, 1932, and 1936. The Olympic Winter Games take place every four years and are held two years after each Summer Olympics.

WHOOSH!

The fastest Winter Olympics sport is luge. Athletes sled down an ice track feet first at speeds of more than 90 miles per hour.



The Olympic rings in Cortina, Italy, with the Dolomites mountain range behind them

Team uniforms

Team USA wears red, white, and blue. For the opening ceremony, athletes will wear a sweater, trousers, and coat designed by Ralph Lauren. The closing ceremony will feature puffer jackets (right) by the brand. Nike's 2026 hockey jerseys honor the 1960 men's team that earned the US its first Olympic gold in the sport.



Meet the mascots

A pair of stoats named Tina (left) and Milo (right) became the official mascots of the Games after winning an online poll. Their names pay tribute to the host cities Cortina and Milan. Stoats are small mammals in the same family as otters. The characters were drawn by young Italian students.





begin!



COMING TO AMERICA

The US will host the Olympic Winter Games in Salt Lake City, Utah, in 2034.



Life as an Olympic athlete

For Olympians, the time they will spend in Italy in February is the result of years of training and dedication. Here's what it takes to reach the biggest stage in winter sports.

spends hours training on the ice as well as lifting weights. When snow on the ground is scarce, US cross country skier Jessie Diggins hits the streets on rollerskis (which resemble short skis with wheels).

How they train

Olympic athletes focus on competing in peak physical and mental form. For US snowboarding star Chloe Kim, that has meant working with a therapist to maintain a healthy perspective on her athletic career, as well as rest to recover from a shoulder injury. Canadian snowboarder Mark McMorris tries to pay close attention to what he eats. US figure skater Amber Glenn



Chloe Kim

Where they stay

Athletes will live in six Olympic villages near the competition. The main villages in

Milan and Cortina will offer about 1,700 and 1,400 beds respectively, with hundreds of additional beds at the other four village locations. The villages will feature dining, fitness centers, and wellness areas. The Milan village will be repurposed as student housing after the Games are over.

Athlete housing in Milan



The torch relay

The Olympics kick off with a torch relay. The torch was lit in Olympia, Greece, on November 26 and traveled around that country before reaching Italy in December. It has been carried by about 10,000 people. The blue-green torch is made of recycled metals and weighs 2.3 pounds. It is scheduled to arrive in Milan on February 4.

Lighting the torch



The medals

This year's gold, silver, and bronze medals were designed in collaboration with the Italian State Mint. Each medal is made of recycled metal and features two halves—one representing the athlete and the other representing their team.





Olympics preview



About Milan and Cortina

Milan is a prosperous city in northern Italy known for its beautiful architecture, such as its famous cathedral, the Duomo. It is a financial center, fashion capital, and commercial hub.

Milan is the second most populous city in the country and spans 70 square miles. One of its most legendary residents was the artist and scientist Leonardo da Vinci. *The Last Supper*, one of his most famous works, is displayed at a museum in Milan. This is the city's first time hosting the Olympics. Cortina d'Ampezzo ("Cortina" for short) has hosted the Winter Olympics once before, in 1956. The picturesque town is located at the base of the Dolomites mountain range and is nicknamed the "Queen of the Dolomites."



The Duomo

Olympic venues

Events will take place at 15 main venues throughout Italy. The Opening Ceremony will get underway at the iconic San Siro soccer stadium, while the closing ceremony will be held at a historic amphitheater in Verona. Ice hockey, figure skating, and speed skating events will happen in Milan. Cortina has a stadium for curling and a sliding center for bobsled, luge, and skeleton, plus a skiing center. The rest of the skiing events, snowboarding, and biathlon will take place in other parts of Italy.



LASTING LEGACY

About 86% of permanent venues from previous Olympic Winter Games are still in use.

In snowboard cross, athletes will race a course featuring jumps, drops, and obstacles.

A viewer's guide to the Games

Opening ceremony

The opening ceremony for the 2026 Winter Olympics is set for 2 p.m. ET on February 6. (Because of the Olympics' busy schedule, some competitions will begin one or two days before the ceremony.) For the first time, two Olympic cauldrons will be lit—one in Milan and one in Cortina. Instead of a single Parade of Athletes in one location, there will be four parades at the same time in four locations: Milan's San Siro stadium and venues in Cortina, Livigno, and Predazzo.



San Siro stadium

Week one (February 4–February 12)

The first medals of the Games will be awarded starting on February 7, in sports such as **ski jumping, snowboarding, and speed skating**. Japanese speed skater Miho Takagi will be competing to win her second straight Olympic gold medal in the women's 1,000m event. Many skiing disciplines—including **alpine, cross-country, and freestyle**—will start crowning winners during the first half of competition. Other sports awarding medals in week one include **figure skating and luge**. US skater Ilya Malinin, a dominant force on the ice and a two-time world champion, is making his Olympic debut. In luge, Germany's Max Langenhan has won back-to-back men's singles world championships and will be vying for gold.

Ilya Malinin



Olympics preview



FACT FILE
The 1968 Winter Olympics were the first Olympics to be broadcast in color on television.

Who to watch

Lindsey Vonn is one of the most decorated alpine skiers in history and the only US woman to win Olympic gold in downhill skiing. She came out of a nearly six-year retirement with a goal of competing in this year's Games. Another athlete to watch is Japan's **Ryōyū Kobayashi**, who won gold and silver in ski jumping at the 2022 Beijing Olympics.



Lindsey Vonn



Ryōyū Kobayashi



Elana Meyers Taylor



Jordan Stolz

In bobsled, a notable Olympic veteran is American **Elana Meyers Taylor**. With five Olympic medals, she is the most accomplished Black athlete in Winter

Olympics history. Also in bobsled, the tropical island nation Jamaica returns for its fourth consecutive Olympics, with two-man and four-man sleds led by **Shane Pitter**.

A young US star to watch is world-champion speed skater **Jordan Stolz**, who is looking to win his first Olympic medal at age 21. In figure skating, Japan's **Kaori Sakamoto** is a three-time world champion who is likely competing in her last Olympics. Meanwhile, **Scotty James**, a decorated Australian snowboarder, will be going for gold.

How to watch

The Olympics will be viewed all over the world. In America, the main network for watching the Games is NBC, but some competitions will also be shown on the USA and CNBC networks. For those looking to watch online, all events will be streamed live on Peacock, as well as various NBC apps and websites. Many live events will occur during the day in the US, so NBC will also recap the day's top highlights and stories in a special primetime show every night. See the full schedule at nbcolympics.com/schedule.

Week two (February 13–February 22)

Speed skating and many skiing disciplines will continue to award medals as the Games proceed. US speed skater Erin Jackson, who in 2022 became the first Black woman to win an individual gold medal at a Winter Olympics, will try to repeat that historic feat in the 500m. In alpine skiing, slalom competitions will be taking place—American star Mikaela Shiffrin of the US is a heavy favorite to win gold. In **skeleton**, Mystique Ro of the US will race for her first Olympic medal. The final medals of the Games will be awarded on February 22 in **bobsled, cross-country skiing, curling, and ice hockey**. In hockey, the US men's and women's teams are expected to face Canada in the final rounds as they seek victory.



Erin Jackson



Arena di Verona

Closing ceremony

This ceremony starts at 2:30 p.m. ET on February 22 at the Arena di Verona, an ancient amphitheater. It will be the first closing ceremony at a World Heritage Site. A parade of flags of all attending countries will feature Greece first and Italy last. Then athletes will enter the arena as one unified global family. The Olympic flag will pass to a representative of the 2030 Winter Games host (the French Alps, France). Finally, the Olympic flame will be extinguished, ending this year's Games.



FAMILY TREE

There are more than 20 species of prehistoric humans that have been identified from fossils.



An artist's rendering of early human ancestors

Ancient ape species walked upright

A small bump on the leg bone of an ape species that lived about 7 million years ago indicates that it was bipedal (able to walk upright on two legs), according to a new study. The bump, called a femoral tubercle, appears only on the femur bone of bipedal hominins (modern humans and our ancestors). That would make the species, called *Sahelanthropus tchadensis*, the oldest known bipedal hominin.

Walking on two legs is one of the most significant developments in the evolution (development of an animal or plant slowly over time) of humans from our ape-like ancestors. Scientists still do not know much about how it happened though.

Fossils belonging to *Sahelanthropus tchadensis* were first found in the early 2000s in Chad, in Africa. Based on an initial study of its skull, the placement of its spine, and its leg and forearm bones, scientists believed the species was bipedal.

However, these claims were controversial in the scientific community. *Sahelanthropus tchadensis* lived at about the same time as the last common ancestor of humans and apes. Some scientists said it wasn't a hominin but an ancient ape closer to chimps than to humans.

For the recent study, a team led by scientists at New York University (NYU) analyzed 3D scans of the leg and arm bones of *Sahelanthropus tchadensis* and compared them to other living and extinct ape species. They found that it had muscles around its hips that would have helped it stand, walk, and run, as well as a twist in the leg bone that would have helped it move forward.

But the most convincing piece of evidence — the femoral tubercle — was discovered almost by accident. "It's a very subtle little bump that I actually didn't identify initially by looking at the fossil but by rubbing my thumb along it," said Scott Williams, an anthropologist at NYU and lead author of the study. The femoral tubercle is the point at which the largest and most powerful ligament (band of connective tissue) in the human body attaches to bone. It is crucial to the ability to walk upright.

Sahelanthropus tchadensis also had curved arm bones, however, which meant it had evolved to climb trees and likely spent much of its time in them. It may have resembled modern-day chimps and bonobos more than humans. But, Williams said, when it was on the ground, it walked on two legs.



The skull of *Sahelanthropus tchadensis*

A common ancestor



A group of fossils found in Africa are 773,000 years old and may belong to the last common ancestor of modern humans and our closest prehistoric relatives, the Neanderthals and Denisovans. Pinpointing their age was an important discovery because they are the first fossils ever found in Africa from that period.

Scientists studied lower jawbones (shown above), teeth, and backbones found in a cave in Casablanca, Morocco. To determine the fossils' age, they carefully analyzed the chemical makeup of the rocks and dirt around them. The fossils dated back to about the same time that modern humans, Neanderthals, and Denisovans were first separating from their shared ancestor and evolving into distinct species. The finding supports the theory that modern humans first appeared in Africa.



Panels installed on Chinese space station

China's space agency has reported that astronauts installed panels on the outside of Tiangong, the country's space station, to protect it from space junk (objects humans have left in space). Tiangong orbits Earth, and astronauts live there for a few months at a time to carry out science experiments.

Some space junk is big, like human-made satellites that no longer work. Other pieces are much smaller, like pieces that have fallen off rockets or spacecraft or even flakes of paint.

Most space junk moves fast: Some pieces can travel at speeds of 18,000 miles per hour. This poses a danger to other spacecraft. There are about 34,000 pieces of space junk that are at least 4 inches in size orbiting Earth as well as millions of smaller pieces.

Officials at the Chinese space agency decided to install the panels after a spacecraft called Shenzhou-20, which transports astronauts to and from Tiangong, was damaged. It was due to bring three astronauts back to Earth, but tests revealed cracks in its window.

Scientists believe the window was damaged by space junk that hit it.

Two astronauts on Tiangong, Zhang Lu and Wu Fei, performed an eight-hour spacewalk outside the station to install the new panels. While they were doing that, they also gave the outside of the station a full inspection to ensure that all was well.

The three astronauts were delayed for nine days while another spacecraft was sent up to bring them home. They made a safe return to Earth.

An artist's rendering of space junk



WHAT'S IN A WORD?
The name Tiangong means "heavenly palace" in the Mandarin Chinese language.



A new Smart Lego set



Electronic Legos use light and sound

The Danish toy company Lego is giving its blocks a makeover. The new Smart Play system will have interactive pieces that produce sound and light and respond to movement.

The system's three components are Smart Bricks, Minifigures, and Tags. The 2-by-4-inch Smart Brick has a computer chip, which is like a brain, and sensors that detect tilt and movement. It also has built-in speakers and colorful lights. Bricks are activated by Tags or Minifigures.

Tags are small, preprogrammed pieces that tell Bricks what object or living thing they are. For example, you could build a helicopter out of regular Legos and add a helicopter Tag to it. A Smart Brick detects the Tag. When you move your aircraft in the air, the Brick makes whirring propeller sounds. The Minifigures are characters, like a police officer or a pilot, that trigger other reactions.

The new system debuts in March with three Star Wars sets.



A drinking vessel made from a fruit



A gourd carafe

Single-use disposable cups create trash, and many end up in landfills. To address this problem, designers in Brooklyn, New York, set out to grow cups and carafes rather than produce them. The result is a drinking vessel made from a gourd—a fruit that is similar to a squash or pumpkin.

The team 3D-printed molds in different shapes, like cups and carafes, then grew gourds inside them. The fruit takes on the shape of the mold. Then, when it's dried out, its tough skin is watertight and can hold liquids. When the vessels are discarded, they break down naturally.



Sports



Jaxon Smith-Njigba (right) of the Seattle Seahawks

TOP TEAMS
The New England Patriots and Pittsburgh Steelers have each won six Super Bowls, the most of any NFL franchise.

Big event for NFL stars



This year, for the first time, the NFL Pro Bowl Games will take place during the week leading up to the Super Bowl. It will feature skills competitions and end with an AFC vs. NFC flag football game on February 3. The rosters include Josh Allen, Amon-Ra St. Brown, Ja'Marr Chase, and Christian McCaffrey.

Patriots, Seahawks make Super Bowl

The NFL (National Football League) conference championship games were held on January 25 to determine which teams will play in the Super Bowl on February 8. In the AFC (American Football Conference) game, the New England Patriots beat the Denver Broncos, 10–7. In the NFC (National Football Conference) game, the Seattle Seahawks beat the Los Angeles Rams, 31–27. The Patriots and Seahawks are headed to a rematch of the 2015 Super Bowl.

The Broncos were the top-seeded (ranked) team in the AFC, and the Patriots were number two. The Broncos' star quarterback (QB), Bo Nix, was injured in their last game, so backup QB Jarrett Stidham faced the Patriots in his first

start of the season. He helped his team take an early 7–0 lead but fumbled in the second quarter, which set up a game-tying touchdown. In the third quarter, the Patriots were up 10–7 when a snowstorm arrived. After that, the teams combined for only 50 yards in the fourth quarter. With less than five minutes to go, the Patriots blocked a Rams field goal, essentially securing the victory.



Drake Maye

Last season, the Patriots had a 4–13 record. But thanks to QB Drake Maye, who is in his second year as a pro, and new head coach Mike Vrabel, the team made their 12th Super Bowl, an NFL record.

The Seahawks were the top seed in the NFC, and the Rams were the fifth seed. Both offenses

were outstanding in their game, and Seattle led 17–13 at halftime. A key play took place early in the third quarter when the Seahawks recovered a Rams fumble deep in opposing territory. Seattle scored on the first play of their resulting possession to add to their lead. The Rams then battled back and cut Seattle's lead to four points. Late in the fourth quarter, the Rams came close to scoring a touchdown that would have put them ahead, but they were stopped by the Seahawks in a play that ended up sealing the win.

Seahawks QB Sam Darnold threw for 346 yards and three touchdowns, and their wide receiver Jaxon Smith-Njigba, who led the NFL in receiving yards in the regular season, caught 10 passes for 153 yards and a touchdown. The Seahawks will be playing in their fourth Super Bowl.

THIS WEEK'S WINNERS...

TENNIS

Rising US stars had big wins at the Australian Open, one of the four Grand Slams. In women's action on January 23, Iva Jovic, age 18, who was seeded 29th, upset Jasmine Paolini of Italy, the seventh seed. Two days later on the men's side, 25th seed Learner Tien, age 20, beat 11th-seeded Daniil Medvedev of Russia. Tien is the youngest man to reach the tournament's quarterfinals in 11 years.

Iva Jovic



SOCCER

In an exhibition (friendly) match on January 24, the US Women's National Team beat Paraguay, 6–0. One of the goals was scored by Trinity Rodman, who also plays in the NWSL. The match came days after she signed the biggest contract in that league's history.

GOLF

The world's top golfer, Scottie Scheffler of the US, won the American Express Golf Tournament on January 25. It was his 20th career win on the PGA Tour.



GIVING BACK
Unrivaled star Paige Bueckers won \$50,000 in a recent free-throw challenge, then pledged that amount to help families in her hometown.

South Carolina
vs. Oklahoma on
January 22

Thrilling games in college hoops

The 2025–26 NCAA (National Collegiate Athletic Association) Division 1 women’s basketball season is in full swing, and the action on the court is heating up. Each team is now playing more opponents from their own conference, creating key matchups as they look toward the end of the regular season in March. In recent games, the nation’s top team remained strong, while another team had its undefeated streak broken.

One of the best teams this season is the second-ranked University of South Carolina. However, on January 22, they were challenged on the road by 16th-ranked University of Oklahoma. South Carolina controlled the first half of the game and had a seven-point lead at halftime, but Oklahoma erased the deficit early in the third quarter and were up by two as the fourth began.

Oklahoma tied the game with 18 seconds left, forcing overtime. They dominated the court in the extra period and went on to win, 94–82, handing South Carolina their second loss of the season. Oklahoma starter Aaliyah Chavez had 26 points.

The number-one-ranked team is the University of Connecticut (UConn), the defending national champions. They have had a remarkable start this season and improved to 21–0 after beating Seton Hall University, 92–52, on January 24. Sarah Strong led the way for UConn with 17 points, six rebounds, and five assists.

The next day, South Carolina met fifth-ranked Vanderbilt University, who began the game with a 20–0 record. South Carolina bounced back from their loss to Oklahoma, though, and handed Vanderbilt their first loss, with a 103–74 victory.



COACH OF THE WEEK

Coach’s Name: **Taly Haffar**

Organizations: **Town North YMCA (soccer), Dallas Premier Volleyball Club**

“My dad, aka Coach Taly, encourages kids to do their best and be relentless! He has integrity, empathy, and a true competitive spirit. He motivates players by helping them through tough drills and practices step-by-step. He makes soccer fun by filling up a ‘prize bucket’ for our last practice of the season. He’s the best coach I know and, as a bonus, the best dad in the universe!” Zain, 10, Texas



To nominate a Coach of the Week, send your coach’s name, photo, sport, and team to hello@theweekjunior.com. Include your name, age, state, and a few reasons why your coach is great.

SPOTLIGHT ON...



Hudson Miller

AGE: 20 SPORT: ICE HOCKEY
TEAM: YALE UNIVERSITY

Entering the rink I started playing ice hockey at the age of 3. There is so much to love about the sport. It is the ultimate team game.

Training plan During the season, we practice four to five times a week and play games on the weekends. In the spring and summer, I skate two to three times a week. I focus on skating and edge work since that’s the most important part of hockey, along with passing, shooting, and puck handling.

Mind matters I am lucky to have a strong support system of family and friends. Life has its ups and downs, and leaning on the people around me in both the good and tough times has helped me stay grounded.

Finding balance Playing hockey while keeping up with academics can be challenging, but it’s manageable. Learning organization and time management in high school helped me build routines, like getting up early to finish schoolwork before class.

Major victory One of my proudest accomplishments was winning the 2023 New England Championship with my high school. Winning a championship is incredibly difficult, and doing it with teammates who became my best friends made it even more special.

Best advice Enjoy the moment. It’s easy to focus on what’s ahead, but staying present and soaking up time with your friends is so important—you’ll look back one day and wish you could relive it all again.





ICE PACK
The world's first organized skating club was the Edinburgh Skating Club in Scotland, founded in the 1740s.

Finding Her Edge

A drama series about skaters

Finding Her Edge is based on a novel about a teen ice dancer's complicated life.

The upcoming Olympics will bring the thrills of real-life sports to TV, but in the meantime, Netflix has released a new fictional series set in the world of figure skating. *Finding Her Edge*, based on Jennifer Iacopelli's 2022 young adult novel of the same name, combines athletic dreams with drama and romance. All eight episodes are now streaming.

Finding Her Edge follows elite ice dancer Adriana Russo (played by Madelyn Keys), a Canadian teen from a family of skating champions. When the family's skating rink begins to struggle financially and her sister is injured, Adriana needs to sign with sponsors so she can bring in money. She teams up with a new partner, Brayden Elliot (Cale Ambrozic), a talented and well-known skater. Things get complicated, though, when her former partner and crush, Freddie, returns to her rink to train with a new partner of his own.

Fans of the book will notice some differences in the TV adaptation. Some new storylines have been added, and some from the book have been cut. The TV characters are also more mature than the original ones. (The series is rated TV-PG.)



Although Keys and Ambrozic both knew how to skate before the show, neither had competed in ice dancing or any kind of figure skating at all. In fact, Ambrozic grew up playing hockey, so he faced the extra challenge of learning to glide around on a completely different type of skates. He told *The Week Junior* he "ate ice" — an expression for falling — "quite a few times, but Maddie showed me the way." The actor said he saw similarities between Brayden and himself. "I connect with his competitiveness — to put everything else on hold to win," he said. "That's been building in me since hockey."

Ambrozic and Keys trained for several weeks before production began and continued to practice throughout filming. "We had some really great teachers who taught us as much as they could in the time that we had — and some even better doubles who did all the hard, impressive stuff," Keys told *The Week Junior*.

The actress said she appreciates how her character's pursuit of success is celebrated in the series. "Adriana has a real drive," she said. That extends to the character's desire to help people as well. "Sometimes it's misguided," she said, "but the intention is pure."

New sports documentary



Glitter & Gold: Ice Dancing is a new documentary series on Netflix that goes behind the scenes as three real pairs of top ice dancers prepare to compete at the 2026 Milan-Cortina Winter Games in Italy. It premieres on February 1 and follows Madison Chock and Evan Bates of the US (above), Piper Gilles and Paul Poirier of Canada, and Laurence Fournier Beaudry and Guillaume Cizeron of France. It is rated TV-14.

Viewers will see what goes into their training, costumes, and performances and will also learn about their lives. For example, Chock and Bates are married to each other, while Cizeron is coming out of retirement and trying to adjust to having a new partner in Fournier Beaudry. Director Kate Walsh, who also made the documentary *Simone Biles: Rising*, said the series focuses on relationships — "with your partner, your coaches, and even the judges."



Milo Manheim



Teagan Croft

WOW!
In the animated film *Tangled*, Rapunzel's hair is 70 feet long and consists of more than 100,000 strands.

Stars of live-action *Tangled* named

A live-action version of the Disney animated musical *Tangled* is in the works, and the actors who will play the lead roles have been announced. Teagan Croft has been cast as long-haired princess Rapunzel, and Milo Manheim will play Flynn Rider, the charming thief-turned-hero. The film will be directed by Michael Gracey, who also directed *The Greatest Showman*. It is scheduled to be released in 2027.

Tangled is a fantasy adventure based on the Brothers Grimm fairy tale "Rapunzel." It follows a princess who has been locked away in a tower for most of her life, then ventures into the outside world with the help of a roguish thief. The film, which came out in 2010, was praised for its humor, modern themes, and music. It featured the song "I See the Light," which was nominated for an Oscar.



Flynn and Rapunzel

Manheim is already very familiar to Disney audiences. He played Zed in the popular *Zombies* film franchise. Croft, meanwhile, is an Australian actress best known for playing Rachel Roth, also known as Raven, in the DC teen superhero series *Titans*. She also starred as real-life sailor Jessica Watson in the 2023 film *True Spirit*.

After the casting news was announced, a 2025 clip of Manheim talking about the idea of playing Flynn went viral. In it, he said *Tangled* was "a movie I grew up on—it's probably my favorite animated musical." His mother, award-winning TV actress Camryn Manheim, shared her excitement about his role in an Instagram post. Next to a screenshot of the casting news, she wrote, "There is no one on this planet who could play Flynn Rider better than you, Milo."



3 MORE PICKS TO ENJOY THIS WEEK



WATCH: PUPPY BOWL XXII

This annual event raises awareness of rescue dogs and pet adoption. This year, 150 dogs from 72 shelters across the US will make up Team Ruff and Team Fluff, who will try to get chew toys to their end zones. (Animal Planet, TBS, truTV, and Discovery Channel on February 8 at 2 p.m. ET; streaming on Max and Discovery+)



LISTEN: ICE LIONS

Kenya's first ice hockey team inspired this story, which is featured on the *Imagination Amplified* podcast. It was recorded in Nairobi, Kenya, and follows John Kitumaini and his friends as they recruit teammates, raise money, and play their first games. (Major podcast platforms, the GZM Shows app, and gzmshows.com.)



WATCH: PARENTHOOD

A new five-part *Nature* series highlights animal parents around the world. Each episode focuses on animals in a specific environment and includes wild dogs in Africa's Zambezi grasslands, frogs in the Amazon jungle, and orcas in the waters near Australia. Viewers will find out about the clever ways they raise and protect their young. (PBS)



READER RECOMMENDS



Stranger Things TV-14 (Netflix)

"This show is set in the 1980s in the fictional town of Hawkins, Indiana, and follows a group of kids after their friend Will disappears mysteriously. While searching for him, they uncover supernatural mysteries, secret government experiments, and a dark parallel world called the Upside Down. Monsters also appear, forcing friends and family to work together to save their small town. At the center of it all is Eleven, a girl with psychic abilities. The show is inspired by 1980s pop culture, classic sci-fi and horror movies, and conspiracy-theory stories." Jakob, 11, Pennsylvania

Do you have a film or TV show to recommend to other kids? Send your review to hello@theweekjunior.com.



Book club

THIS WEEK'S BOOK

The Beasts of Winter

By J. C. Cervantes

Five years ago, the sinister Winter Queen transformed Fetch, a magical being, into a fox and kidnapped his younger sister, Violet. Time is now running out for Fetch, who earns money by making magical garments, to rescue Violet from the winter palace. Violet left behind a handkerchief with magical stitches that belonged to their mother. The handkerchief connects his heart to Violet's, but one stitch disappears each day and he has fewer than a dozen left.

With the help of several mystical creatures, including Garzo, a fairy, and Beckblade, a mini dragon, Fetch goes on a difficult quest to find his sister and unfurl another evil secret plot the queen has hatched. Along the way, Fetch encounters a ghost, giant worms, and other mystical creatures that get him one step closer to Violet.

But there's another obstacle: Fetch is possessed by a spirit that's draining his magic. Will he ever be reunited with Violet and save the kingdom? This suspenseful fantasy adventure is the popular companion to *The Daggers of Ire*, although you don't need to read that book to follow the plot. If you're a fan of the *Witchlings* or *The Land of Stories* series, this book may be especially appealing to you.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS FOR YOUR BOOK CLUB

Do you think that Garzo, the fairy, is too harsh toward Fetch? Explain your answer.

Which character would you most want to have as a partner on a quest? Why?

How does Fetch become more confident in himself as the story progresses?

What scene in the story felt the most suspenseful?

Why are Fetch and Violet lucky to have each other?

If you could order a piece of magical clothing from Fetch, what would it be?

Using one word or phrase, how would you describe this book?



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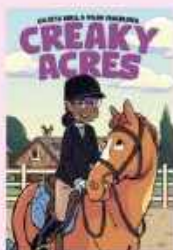
New Kid

By Jerry Craft

The only graphic novel that has ever won the Newbery Medal focuses on Jordan, a Black student attending a

mostly white private school. He tries to navigate the school's culture while staying true to himself. Ages 8–12

You might like...



Creaky Acres

By Calista Brill,

illustrated by Nilah Magruder

In this graphic novel, a 10-year-old equestrian named Nora leaves behind her best friends

when she moves to a rural community for her mom's job. As a Black student, she faces racism at her new school. Ages 8–12



Guess the book this quote comes from

"When given the choice between being right and being kind, choose kind."

Hint: The best-selling 2012 novel inspired a Choose Kind movement in schools and was made into a movie.

Answer: *Wonder* by R.J. Palacio. Augie, a boy with a facial deformity, attends a mainstream school for the first time. His fifth-grade teacher Mr. Browne writes this line on the blackboard and discusses it with the class.



THIS WEEK'S AUTHOR

J. C. Cervantes

J. C. Cervantes is a best-selling author of books for kids, including *The Storm Runner* series, inspired by Mayan mythology. She received the 2023 New Mexico Governor's Award for Excellence in the Arts, which honors artists who enrich the state with their work.

What inspired this book?

This is a companion novel to my book *The Daggers of Ire*, and when I was writing it, this cursed, magical fox with an enchanted coat jumped onto the page. I wasn't expecting him, and I really fell in love with his character. I knew he had a story to tell and that an entire book needed to be told from his point of view—his own adventure, what was going on in his life, why he was cursed, and why he wears the enchanted coat.

Do you relate to any of the characters?

One of the characters that I really relate to is a tiny dragon named Beckblade. He has so much hope and optimism. There's a part of me, especially with the world we're dealing with today, that still wants to have that childlike, open-eyed optimism.

What do you enjoy about writing fantasy books?

I love the possibilities. Magic opens up the world to me as a creator in a way that allows me to toss out a lot of rules. When I'm building a world, I get to ignore things like reality and gravity. When I'm creating, I get to play!



Is there a book that had an especially strong effect on you as a child?

Little Witch by Anna Elizabeth Bennett.

Best advice for aspiring writers?

Just give yourself the ability to dream and also to write without judgment.

If you could get lost in one magical world, where would you go?

The world of *The Secret Garden* by Frances Hodgson Burnett. That would just be wonderful.

What do you do in your spare time?

I love to hike trails in the forest, read, and spend time with my family and my dogs. I also foster dogs. I have a real affinity with animals, and I like to volunteer to help improve their lives.

Are there any Super Bowl snacks you're excited for?

Chips and queso!



3 action-packed football books

Tackle one of these titles before the Super Bowl on February 8.



Big Book of WHO Football

By Sports Illustrated Kids

This almanac is packed with records you can share with family

during the big game. For instance, former San Francisco 49ers quarterback Steve Young threw six touchdown passes in a Super Bowl—the most in the annual game's nearly 60-year history. Colorful action photos make the book especially fun to browse. Ages 8+



Inspiring Stories of Football Greats

By Skyler Trepel, illustrated by Lorenzo Fornaciari

Find out how famous football players from the

past and present have overcome adversity in their lives. Popular quarterbacks Patrick Mahomes, Tom Brady, and Peyton Manning are among the players featured. The book includes each player's top achievements and breakout moments. Ages 6–9

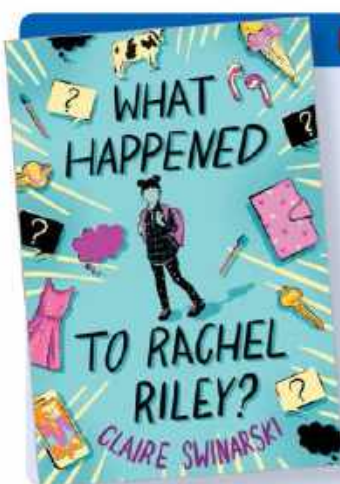


Rocket Arm

By Tim Green

In this riveting novel, an exceptional 11-year-old quarterback gets a chance to play football for an elite athletic boarding school.

But his experience takes an unexpected turn when he finds himself in the middle of a mystery involving the coach's healing powers. With lots of on-the-field action, this story, written by a former pro football player, is hard to put down. Ages 8–12



Reader recommends

What Happened to Rachel Riley? By Claire Swinarski

"In seventh grade, Rachel Riley was super popular. But now in eighth grade, she's considered a social outcast—nobody even talks to the once-popular Rachel anymore. A new student at the school, 12-year-old Anna Hunt, is determined to find out why and sets out to investigate and learn the truth. This book is awesome because it really hooks you and makes you want to know what happened to Rachel Riley!" Olivia, 9, Connecticut

Do you have a book to recommend? We want to hear about it! With an adult's help, please send your review to hello@theweekjunior.com.

Find out more about *The Week Junior* Book Club and check out our previous titles at kids.theweekjunior.com/bookclub.





How to...

Celebrate the Winter Olympics!

Get ready to watch the 2026 Games in Milan and Cortina, Italy, from February 6 to February 22 by creating one or all of these crafts and recipes. Find out more about the competition in our Olympics preview starting on page 12!

Hockey rink game

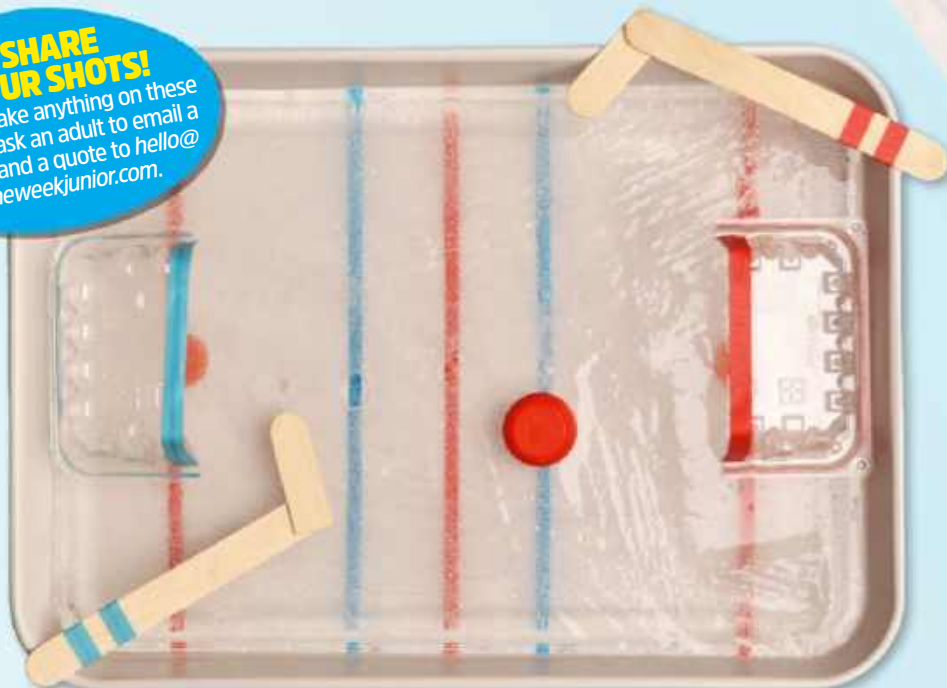
What you'll need

- Rectangular baking pan or roasting pan
- Colored tape
- Dot sticker (optional)
- Recycled plastic berry box or berry basket
- Optional: Two resealable sandwich bags filled with coins, dry rice, or beans (to use as weights)
- Scissors
- 3 wide craft sticks
- Hot glue or white glue
- Plastic cap or large button

Instructions

1. Add strips of tape to the inside bottom of the pan to make the center and goal lines, as shown. Cut the dot sticker in half and place each half on a goal line.
2. Make the goals: Cut off the lid of the berry basket and recycle it. Cut the remaining piece in half to make two goals, and add colored tape to the edges as decoration.
3. Pour about an inch (or a little more) of water into the pan. Place it outside if it's cold where you live,

SHARE YOUR SHOTS!
If you make anything on these pages, ask an adult to email a photo and a quote to hello@theweekjunior.com.



or set it on a flat surface in the freezer. Position the goals on the rink. Use small weights (like sandwich bags filled with dry rice or beans) if needed to hold them in place. Freeze overnight.

4. Make the hockey sticks: Cut 2 inches off both ends of one craft stick. Glue one 2-inch piece to

the bottom of a craft stick at an angle to make a blade. Repeat with the remaining stick. Add tape stripes to decorate the handles, if you like.

5. Play! Use a plastic cap or button as the puck. Once your rink starts to melt too much, place it outside or in the freezer to refreeze.

Olympic symbol brownie bites

Ingredients

- 1 (16- to 18-ounce) box brownie mix
- 1 (16-ounce) can chocolate frosting
- ¼ cup powdered sugar
- Blue, brown, red, yellow, and green chocolate pastel candies
- ½ cup white melting candy wafers

Instructions

1. Heat oven to 350° F. Coat a mini muffin tin well with cooking spray.
2. In a large bowl, prepare the brownie mix as directed on the package. Fill each well of the prepared muffin tin ¾ full. With an adult's help, bake the brownies until set around the edges and mostly cooked through, about 18–20 minutes.
3. Let the brownies cool for 2 minutes, then quickly turn them out onto a cooling rack. Flip them right side up to cool completely.
4. Working with one brownie at a time, top it with the frosting, then

use a shaker or sieve to dust it with powdered sugar.

5. Press a blue, brown, red, yellow, and green candy into the top, as shown, to mimic Olympic rings. Repeat with the remaining brownies.
6. To finish, place melting candy wafers in a microwave-safe bowl and heat in 30-second bursts, stirring vigorously between each, until melted.
7. Use a toothpick or the end of a bamboo skewer to apply a white circle of melted chocolate in the center of each candy, as pictured, then serve. Makes 24 brownie bites.





SPECIAL SYMBOL

The colors of the Olympic rings represent the unity of the five inhabited continents of the world.

Five rings T-shirt

What you'll need

- Blank T-shirt
- Scrap cardboard
- Acrylic craft paint in blue, black, red, yellow, and green
- Clean, empty yogurt container (look for one with a thin, flat rim at the bottom or top) or a paper cup
- Paper plates
- Paintbrush
- Paper towels

Instructions

1. Place the cardboard inside the shirt to keep paint from bleeding through.
2. Make a guide for painting the rings: Find a printable Olympic symbol online. Size it to match your yogurt container, then print it out. Slide it into the shirt on top of the cardboard and center it exactly where you want the design. Tape it to the cardboard if you'd like.
3. Squeeze a little paint onto a paper plate. Use the paintbrush to spread it into a thin, even layer.
4. Dip or "bounce" the container rim into the paint a few times until the rim is evenly coated. (Check it before the next step.)
5. Press the whole rim onto the T-shirt to print your first Olympic ring.
6. Rinse the paint off the container and wipe it with a paper towel until it's completely clean and dry.
7. Repeat with the four remaining colors.
8. Allow the paint to dry, then remove the paper and the cardboard.



Flaming torch cupcakes

What you'll need

- Cake mix (and the ingredients listed on the package)
- 12 flat-bottomed ice cream cones
- Cupcake pan or baking sheet
- Can of creamy (not whipped) white frosting
- Marshmallows (optional)
- Yellow and red food coloring
- Three small bowls
- Icing spatula or a butter knife
- Gold chocolate coins for serving (optional)

Instructions

1. Heat oven to 350° F. Mix the cake batter according to the box instructions. Fill the cones about $\frac{3}{4}$ full with batter.
2. Place the cones in the cupcake pan or on the baking sheet and bake for about 15 minutes or until they are lightly golden on top.
3. Remove from the oven and allow the cupcakes to cool completely.
4. Divide the frosting among the three bowls. Stir a few drops of yellow food coloring into one, red into another, and a mix of red and yellow into the last to make orange.
5. To build a tall flame, "glue" a marshmallow on top of each cupcake with a dab of frosting.
6. Place the cupcake torches in the refrigerator for 20 minutes to firm up cupcakes before icing them.
7. Use the spatula to add frosting to the top. If the frosting is very soft and hard to build up, spread on a layer, chill for 20 to 30 minutes, then add more. Add a little of each color to create the look of a flame. Makes 12 torches.

WARNING!

Ask an adult's permission before using the oven or using a hot glue gun.



Puzzles



Word ladder

To change the word NICE into the word WORK, use each clue to fill in a word that is only one letter different from the word before it. If you get stuck, try solving from the bottom up.



Number of innings in a baseball game

Common answer to the question "How are you?"

Locate what you're looking for

"I'm _____ of you" ("I like you")

Creator of the Model T automobile

Give a shape to

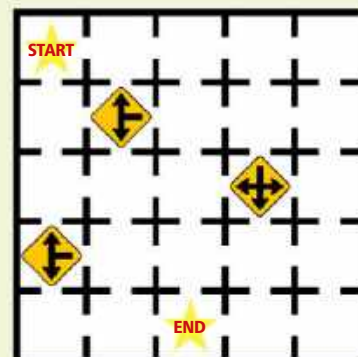
What people say the early bird gets

N I C E

W O R K

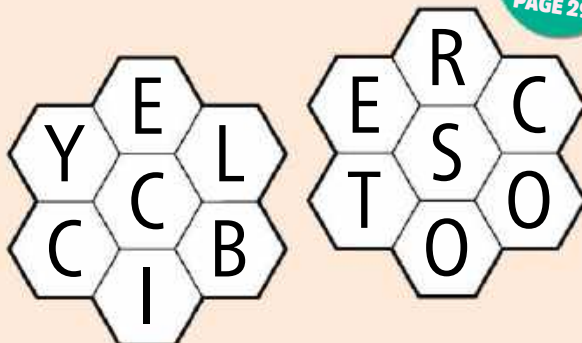
DETOURS

Draw one continuous path from START to END that goes through every single square without crossing itself. For squares with signs, you may only enter at the arrow's base, and you may only make a turn in the direction of an arrow shown. (NEED A HINT? Check the bottom of the page.)



STEPPING STONES

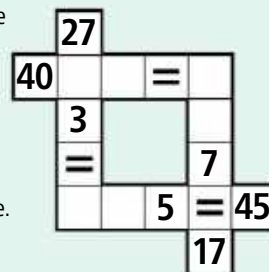
Each figure hides a seven-letter kind of motorless transportation. To find each one, start anywhere and move in an unbroken path through letters that share a border (no jumping!), using each letter once.



ANSWERS
CAN BE
FOUND ON
PAGE 29.

Crossmath

Fill each empty box with a number or a mathematical symbol (+, -, ×, or ÷) to complete the equations across and down. A symbol can be used more than once.



Spot the difference

These two pictures of a robot dog appear to be the same, but take a closer look. There are actually five differences. Can you see them?





Beware of frostbite!

Swimmer's snowy shark sculpture

Outdoor swimmer Fiona Clarke took advantage of freezing temperatures in the Scottish Highlands to create a snow sculpture of a great white shark. She went to a lake that had frozen over, where she had sculpted a penguin the year before. Before Clarke builds her sculptures, she checks to make sure the ice is thick and strong enough to stand on. Some friends helped her sculpt and even joined her for a swim. When the artwork was complete, she briefly entered the water so photos could be taken.



This pup doesn't stay.

Rescue dog makes clever escape

Animal shelter employees in West Virginia were dumbfounded when the 5-year-old dog they called Dawson disappeared overnight. They realized the front door was unlocked, so they checked surveillance footage—which revealed that Dawson had escaped his enclosure, stood on his hind legs, and used his teeth to unlock the door. In fact, the dog was actually named Rufus and had been mistakenly brought to the shelter. He opened the door and ran home to his family. "That is one smart little dog," said the shelter's director.



We're jelly of her stash.

A huge collection of cuddly toys

Hope Roberts, age 19, has broken a world record by having the largest collection of Jellycats. This popular brand of stuffed toys has released about 22,000 products since its launch in 1999. Roberts' collection began with a small toy rabbit she found at a charity shop for about \$26, and she kept collecting them because she thought they were "really cute." Now she has 877 different items. She said she wouldn't be able to pick a favorite from the collection because "I love them all too much."

Real or fake?



Have buses gone wild?

Koala cheers up passengers

A bus company in Australia has devised an inventive way to bring joy to riders on their daily commute. As part of a program to improve passengers' mental health, the company introduced a support animal on some routes in the city of Brisbane. No one is allowed to touch the koala, named Peri, who clings to a metal pole inside the buses, but the company said the animal boosted people's spirits and kept their focus off their phones. The idea may be expanded onto other bus routes. Is this story true or a high-koality lie?*

*Faked! A koala did find its way onto a bus in Australia, but only because a bus driver spotted it along a busy road and brought it on board to keep it safe. The animal was later collected by rescuers and returned to the wild.



Your turn

Editor's note

When I was growing up, I was lucky enough to attend the 1980 Winter Olympics in Lake Placid, New York. My brother Jon and I were so excited as we stood on Whiteface Mountain and watched alpine skiers race by. That was also the year when the underdog US hockey team achieved a "miracle on ice" by defeating the powerhouse Soviet Union in a thrilling 4-3 game. US speed skater Eric Heiden also astonished the world by becoming the first athlete to win five gold medals in the same Olympic Games. Last summer, Jon and I returned to Lake Placid together and relived those wonderful memories. This year, the Winter Games are taking place in Italy, and our editorial team is pleased to bring you two special sections: a preview of the action (p12) plus Olympic recipes and crafts to help you celebrate (p24). If you make any of them, we'd love to know! Send a photo and a quote to hello@theweekjunior.com.



Andrea Barbalich
Editorial Director

CHARITY OF THE WEEK



Best Buddies

This organization supports people with intellectual and developmental disabilities, such as Down syndrome and autism. One of its main missions is to foster one-to-one friendships between people with and without disabilities. It also provides leadership development and assists with independent living. Find out more at bestbuddies.org.



Selling soap for a good cause

“For my entrepreneurship club, I started a project called Bubbles and Baubles where I sell soaps with charms inside. I wanted to raise money for Urban Alchemy, an organization that helps keep cities, including San Francisco, safe. I use glycerin and shea butter soap bases to hand-pour the soaps into different designs. My soaps are special because each one has a charm inside that can be used for jewelry after the soap is used up. We sold the soaps to friends and family and at a local holiday fair. I thought we would raise about \$100, but we ended up raising over \$800! This project was super fun, and I learned a lot from it.”



Lisette, 11, California

RIDDLE OF THE WEEK

What's the longest six-letter word?

Smiles—there's a mile between the first and last letters.

Have you done something interesting or raised money for a cause you care about? Whatever you're up to, we want to hear about it at hello@theweekjunior.com.

Ideas for making a difference

Rylie, an 11-year-old from Virginia, told us that kids can help their community by picking up trash in the neighborhood or mowing a neighbor's lawn. Rylie also suggested assisting senior citizens with getting their groceries. What ideas do you have for helping your community or someone you care about? Go to kids.theweekjunior.com/activities to download a form like the one shown at right. Fill it out, then have an adult email it to us at hello@theweekjunior.com. We'll feature some of the submissions on this page in future issues.



THE WEEK
Junior

IT'S YOUR TURN

Email your news, views, and photos to hello@theweekjunior.com.

Your turn



YOUR PHOTOS

We'd love to see pictures you've taken or pictures with you in them! Have an adult email them to us at hello@theweekjunior.com, along with anything you would like us to know about what's happening in the photo.

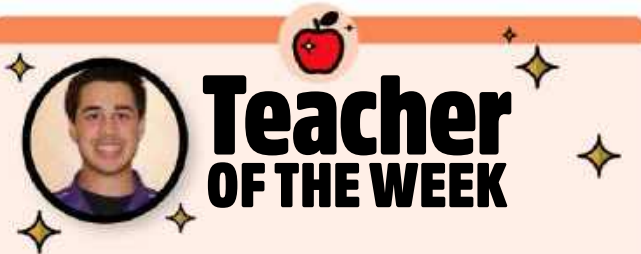


"I enjoyed reading *The Week Junior* during my trip to Santiago, Chile." **Sid, 9, Georgia**

"After collecting every issue of *The Week Junior* during the year, I used some of my favorite images to make a collage bookmark and poster for my room." **Alsa, 12, Indiana**



"I made the black forest smoothie recipe. I used tart frozen cherries and it was good, but I think it would be even better if I used sweet frozen cherries." **Charles, 11, Texas**



Teacher's Name: **Mr. Gunn**

School: **Vernon K-8**

"Mr. Gunn teaches sixth grade social studies and language arts. He takes his job seriously, but his way of teaching is also fun. For example, while we were learning about the Maya civilization, he taught us how to play a Maya ball game. If our class gets out of hand, Mr. Gunn is patient with us. We could go on forever, but these are the best reasons."

Lily, 11, and Leela, 11, Oregon

Nominate your teacher for Teacher of the Week!
Send your reason for the nomination, a photo of your teacher, and your school's name and address to hello@theweekjunior.com.

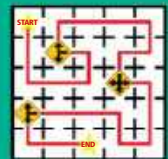
Puzzle answers (from page 26)

Word ladder

NICE
NINE
FINE
FIND
FOND
FORD
FORM
WORM
WORK

Stepping stones

bicycle, scooter



$$\begin{array}{r} 27 \\ 40 \div 4 = 10 \\ 3 \quad + \\ = \quad 7 \\ 9 \times 5 = 45 \\ 17 \end{array}$$



Quiz answers (from page 30) **1** a) Fox **2** 12 **3** True **4** a) Two **5** "Rapunzel"
6 False. Ski mountaineering is making its debut. **7** c) Colorado **8** b) Figure skating
9 b) 18,000 **10** Blitz **11** False. Bears in the south have more active jumping genes.
12 c) University of South Carolina **13** True **14** *All the Blues in the Sky* **15** b) 877

We want to hear from you! To have your letters, photos, nominations, recommendations, or ideas considered for inclusion in the magazine, please include your first name, age, and state with your submission. By emailing your submission to us, you give *The Week Junior* consent to publish it in the magazine and online. Please get your parent/guardian's permission before sending anything to us.



Quiz

How much of this week's news can you remember?

1 In the book *The Beasts of Winter*, Fetch has been transformed into what animal?

a) Fox b) Moose c) Penguin

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

2 How many times have the New England Patriots qualified for the Super Bowl?

3 True or false? NASA astronaut Suni Williams set a record for the most spacewalking time by a woman.

True ☐ False ☐

4 A new study found that lions make how many different sounds when they roar?

a) Two b) Four c) Six

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

5 The animated film *Tangled* was based on what classic fairy tale?

6 True or false? Ski jumping is making its Olympic debut this year.

True ☐ False ☐

7 Which US state has announced plans to reintroduce wolverines into the wild?

a) Wyoming

b) Montana

c) Colorado

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

8 The Netflix series *Finding Her Edge* is about a competitor in what winter sport?

a) Ice hockey

b) Figure skating

c) Speed skating

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐



**ANSWERS
CAN BE
FOUND ON
PAGE 29.**



9 Some pieces of space junk can travel up to how many miles per hour?

a) 1,800

b) 18,000

c) 180,000

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

10 Norwegian chess player Magnus Carlsen recently won his ninth title in what type of chess?

11 True or false? Polar bears in northern Greenland have more active jumping genes than those in the south.

True ☐ False ☐

12 Which women's college basketball team ended Vanderbilt University's undefeated season?

a) University of Connecticut

b) University of Iowa

c) University of South Carolina

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

13 True or false? A small bump on a leg bone led scientists to believe that a 7-million-year-old ape species was able to walk upright.

True ☐ False ☐

14 What book received the 2026 Newbery Medal for best children's book of the year?

15 How many different Jellycats toys has Hope Roberts collected?

a) 733 b) 877 c) 944

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

THE WEEK Junior

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Meet our Spring 2026 Junior Council members!



Aditya, age 10, Washington



Kesli, age 13, North Dakota



Kamen, age 11, Missouri



Nia Janae, age 10, California



Lara, age 10, New Jersey



Rohan, age 8, Virginia



Tae, age 13, New York



In September, we opened applications for our seventh Junior Council class. The response from children across the US was amazing, and each application was terrific! It was a challenge to make a decision. We are excited for the 12 children shown here to join the Council and have their voices heard. Their work will appear in a future issue of the magazine. To find out more about Junior Council and be the first to know about future applications, visit our website at juniorcouncil.theweekjunior.com.



Lucy, age 11, Tennessee



Zara, age 11, Ohio



Elliott, age 10, California



Manvi, age 9, Washington

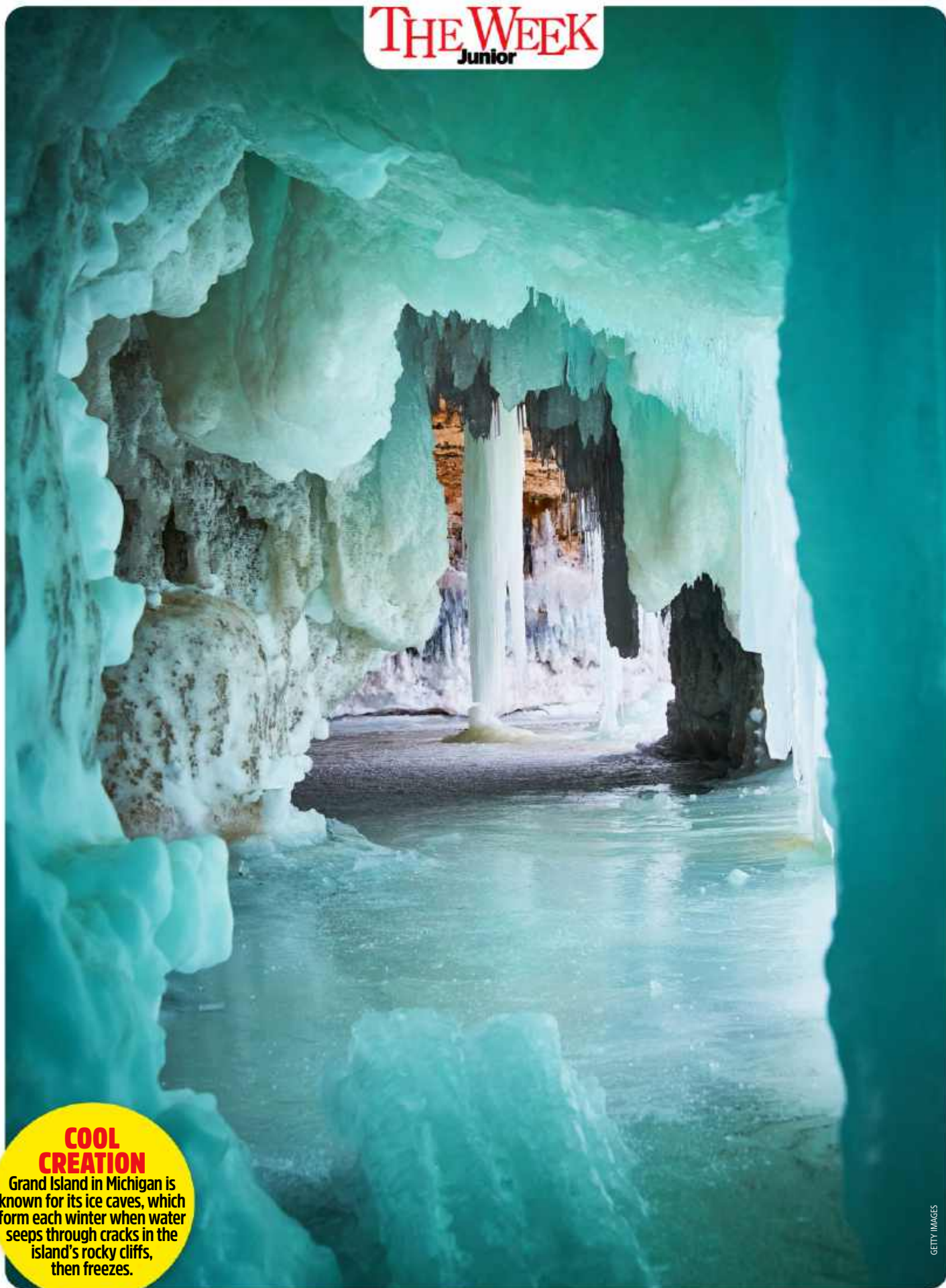


Oscar, age 11, Massachusetts

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The Week Junior and save 67% off the cover price.**

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COOL CREATION

Grand Island in Michigan is known for its ice caves, which form each winter when water seeps through cracks in the island's rocky cliffs, then freezes.